commander in Chittor, passes the ultimate test of ability and worth – the admiration of his foes. Badauni calls him ‘brave and chivalrous’; another Mughal historian describes him as ‘infidel yet valiant’.[20] In fact, Jaimal was not always an enemy of the Mughals. When, long ago, Sharafuddin (Akbar’s brother-in-law gone rogue) had embarked on his conquests in Rajasthan, he had defeated the ruler of Merta with the help of Rajputs who ‘had an old quarrel with the garrison’ of the fort.[21] One of these was Jaimal, who was given command of Merta after its fall. When Sharafuddin rebelled, however, Jaimal’s own loyalty to Akbar became suspect. Unsure of his future in the Mughal court, the Rajput came to Mewar.[22]

Thus, now, Jaimal commanded the defence of Chittorgarh; but other contingents, from other lands, had come to Mewar’s aid, too – Rathaurs led by Sahib Khan; Chauhans under Isar Das; a contingent of expert marksmen led by a musketeer called Ismail; and, finally, Chittorgarh’s civilian population (people’s houses rose ‘several storeys over each other’[23]), tens of thousands of residents who would fight for their fort.

When these defenders saw Akbar’s army, so far below, men of flesh and blood peering up at rock and stone, they jeered.

Undaunted, Akbar mounted his siege, as slowly, as methodically as one of his beloved cheetahs stalking its prey. It took a full month to position his commanders and their soldiers around the base of the hill. Some of these chiefs would take it upon themselves to charge at the fort in flights of valour – much like Adham Khan had once charged at Mankot – but
Akbar discouraged such showboating. It was as useless in any case, as throwing pebbles at the sky. No matter if the Mughals fired their muskets with flair – they would hit only the air, and find themselves, or their horses, shot and killed.

To make any kind of dent in the fort’s defences, Akbar needed to get much closer to it. He issued two orders. Five thousand men, ‘carpenters, stone-masons, smiths, and sappers’,[24] were to work night and day building a *sabat* – a ‘sinuous’ tunnel with roofs of hide and ‘broad, mud wall[s] . . . that balls could not penetrate’[25] – through which the Mughal army might approach the fort in relative safety. Meanwhile, another group of men were to dig their way in secret to the fort walls, pack them with gunpowder and blow them apart.